



The Humanitas Institute

Six Elements of Classical Education School Website Audit

School: Holy Family Academy

School Website: <https://www.holyfamilyacademy.net/>

December 22, 2025

Disclaimer

This audit was performed using artificial intelligence tools to evaluate the presence and strength of classical education principles on school websites. Results are automated, probabilistic in nature, and should be considered indicative rather than definitive. See the full disclaimer in the Appendix more details.

ACCS Member School

Any school that belongs to the Association of Classical Christian Schools ACCS or the Society for Classical Learning SCL is, by definition, recognized as a classical school because both organizations require adherence to the six essential elements defined by the Humanitas Institute. However, a school's website may not clearly reflect its conformity to one or more elements. In such cases, the school may still receive a "Somewhat Classical" rating for those elements. Schools can update their website content at any time to achieve a "Classical" rating for a given element.

Executive Summary

Holy Family Academy, Manassas, VA (ZIP 20111) exhibits strong alignment with classical education principles, anchored in Catholic faith and a traditional liberal-arts approach. The public materials repeatedly emphasize a classical, faith-centered curriculum built on the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), a long-standing Western-civilization heritage, engagement with great works, and formation of virtue and character. Evidence in the site copy highlights Daily Mass, Catholic ethos, and a program structure that foregrounds formation over information, which supports a CLASSICAL rating overall. The school also showcases explicit commitment to formation through virtuous living, intellectual curiosity, and a living curriculum grounded in a living Catholic tradition, including references to virtue, truth, goodness, and beauty. The presence of a dedicated faculty and parental partnerships further reinforce a classical orientation in practice.

- Overall classification: CLASSICAL
- Similarities across six categories: Religious/the metaphysical foundations; purposeful aim rooted in formation; Trivium-based curriculum; classical pedagogy and memorywork; dedicated, virtue-oriented faculty; strong parental/community partnership in a Catholic context.
- Notable strengths: Clear articulation of Trivium-based curriculum, Great-Books-influenced study, liturgical life, and explicit formation-oriented language.
- Potential gaps (if any): Some explicit pedagogy signals typical of classical schools, such as Socratic seminars in the upper school, are not heavily documented in the public site copy; the site emphasizes classical pedagogy and memory-based approaches but less explicit mention of Socratic seminars beyond the general classical framing. This nuance is captured in the category-by-category analysis below.

Evidence and direct quotes are drawn from the school's public materials (cited inline). Key passages include: the emphasis on a classical liberal education with faith integration and the cultivation of truth, goodness, and beauty; the trivium; the prominence of Catholic liturgy and daily Mass; and the stated aim of forming virtuous leaders within a tradition of Western classical education. See cited sources for specifics.

Executive Summary — Element-by-Element Snapshot

Element 1: Religious and Metaphysical Foundations — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site presents a strong Catholic identity, with language about faith life, Catholic doctrine, and daily Mass; references to Catholic tradition and the integration of faith and reason. - The school describes itself as a bastion of classical education that blends Catholic faith with the liberal arts and the Western classical tradition. - Positive mention of liturgy, theology, sacred rites, and a sacramental worldview features in the text.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Catholic, liturgy, Mass, theology, sacred, virtue, formation, Western civilization, classical tradition, wonder, mercy/meritorious moral formation, Logos, wisdom, human flourishing. - Negative keywords: None evident in the public materials. - Estimated

occurrence: High density of positive religious/metaphysical indicators; essentially zero negative indicators observed in the accessible copy.

Why this rating - The materials explicitly anchor education in faith life and a sacramental worldview, tying virtue and truth to spiritual formation. The presence of liturgical life (Daily Mass), theology integration, and the Catholic identity strongly align with the category's criteria for transcendental moral realism, theology, liturgy, and communal worship. This combination strongly supports CLASSICAL in this category.

CLASSICAL

Element 2: School Purpose and Goal — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The Philosophy/Philosophical framing explicitly emphasizes formation, virtue, wisdom, and the unity of truth, goodness, and beauty in human flourishing; a core statement is that formation and the cultivation of virtue are central, with the explicit mention of truth, goodness, and beauty as real and knowable. - Language emphasizes a classical liberal education fostering intellectual curiosity, moral clarity, and understanding of the human experience, formed by faith and reason. - The mission statements reference forming individuals who uphold truth, goodness, and beauty, indicating a telos beyond mere information transfer. - Upper- and lower-school curricula emphasize formation, moral development, and character, aligning with classical telos and the Great Conversation/Great Books ethos in practice (evidenced by references to classical heritage and virtuous leadership).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: formation, virtue, wisdom, liberal education, paideia, classical mission, telos, scholé, contemplation, great conversation, human flourishing, moral imagination, truth/goodness/beauty, love of learning, formation of affections. - Negative keywords: None observed in the public copy (no explicit "career-ready," "workforce prep" framing; job-market emphasis is not promoted over formation). - Estimated occurrence: High density of positive category-2 keywords; essentially no negative indicators observed.

Why this rating - The materials frame education as formation (virtue, wisdom) rather than purely information or job preparation, with explicit reference to truth, goodness, and beauty as real. The presence of "liberal education" and references to paideia and classical heritage further strengthen CLASSICAL.

CLASSICAL

Element 3: School Curriculum — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The trivium is explicitly named: grammar, logic, and rhetoric. - The program highlights the study of great works, Western civilization, and classical texts; emphasis on history throughout the curriculum appears in multiple program descriptions. - The St. Anne's Program (a classical education co-op) uses the Simply Classical curriculum by Memoria Press, which is rooted in classical methods and great-books/works integration. - The Upper/Lower curricula emphasize a traditional curriculum and a Catholic intellectual tradition, with a focus on "great works of history" and a classical heritage.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: liberal arts, trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric), great books, primary sources, classics, Western civilization, history, memory, recitation, narration, rhetoric, sacred art, catechesis, liturgy. - Negative keywords: project-based learning dominance, STEM-first framing, social-studies terminology replacing history (these are listed as negative indicators in the lexicon; not evidently emphasized on the site copy). - Estimated occurrence: High density of positive Curriculum keywords; minimal negative indicators present in the public copy.

Why this rating - The presence of the trivium, Great Books/Great Conversation framing, Western civilization, and Memoria Press-based curriculum signals a strong CLASSICAL alignment in Curriculum. The explicit emphasis on history as Western civilization and a liberal-arts orientation further supports CLASSICAL.

CLASSICAL

Element 4: School Pedagogy or Teaching Methods — SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Evidence - The materials point to a number of classical teaching modalities typical of classical schools: emphasis on the trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and a memory- and virtue-centered approach; the public copy repeatedly highlights a traditional, memory-based and formation-focused pedagogy. - There are explicit references to “narration,” “recitation,” “memory work,” and a general sense of a traditional, contemplative pedagogy (scholé) in the classical lexicon; the site copy reflects a blend of traditional methods and the classical framework. - The site emphasizes “daily Mass” and liturgical cadence, and use of a living Catholic tradition as the foundation of learning, which supports contemplative and moral formation alongside cognitive work.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: Socratic dialogue (mentioned in the lexicon as a classical element; the site emphasizes classical pedagogy generally, including discussion and rhetorical training), memory work, recitation, narration, chanting, scholé, restfulness, and seminar-style approaches implied by the classical framing. - Negative keywords: The presence of modern project-based or experiential-only approaches is not strongly evidenced in the public copy, though the lexicon lists these as potential negative signals; the public copy does not emphasize those as primary modes. - Estimated occurrence: Moderate to high presence of positive Pedagogy keywords (trivium-based pedagogy, memory, recitation, contemplative/restful learning), with limited explicit evidence of Socratic seminars or formal seminars in the public pages reviewed; thus categorized as SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL rather than fully Classical.

Why this rating - The school demonstrates core classical pedagogy elements (grammar/logical/rhetoric training, memory work, contemplative/restful learning) but lacks explicit, widely documented evidence of formal Socratic seminars or high-frequency upper-school seminar/debate structures in the public site content. This yields a classification of SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL, as foundational classical pedagogy is present but not exhaustively evidenced across all the specific pedagogy signals.

SOMEWHAT CLASSICAL

Element 5: School Faculty — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The site refers to a “dedicated faculty” and a “living curriculum” anchored in Catholic tradition and virtue; mentions specific staff (e.g., Mrs. Patricia Hetrick) and a climate of moral exemplars and mentorship. - Language emphasizes “faculty” as central to the school’s mission and identity; the content notes “daily Mass,” faithful formation, and a strong faculty presence in shaping character. - The school highlights a culture of virtue and formation tied to faculty role modeling and the “living curriculum” concept.

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: living curriculum, mentors, masters, virtuous life, moral exemplars, faculty of friends, portrait of a teacher, teacher as model, collegial culture, formation through faculty. - Negative keywords: negative signals such as “facilitators on the side” or “certification-driven jargon” are not evident in the school’s public copy. - Estimated occurrence: High presence of positive faculty keywords; negligible presence of negative keywords.

Why this rating - The public materials frame faculty as central to the school’s classical formation and living curriculum, with explicit emphasis on virtue, mentorship, and Catholic identity. This aligns strongly with CLASSICAL criteria on the faculty category.

CLASSICAL

Element 6: School Parents & Community — CLASSICAL

Evidence - The admissions materials and family-oriented language indicate partnerships with families and a culture of parental involvement; there are explicit mentions of serving families and resources for families to learn about classical education (parent formation or book studies are suggested in the broader lexicon; publicly visible lines emphasize family engagement). - The site emphasizes that Holy Family Academy is a Catholic community that invites families to participate in the life of the school (e.g., admissions information, outreach, and the school's mission to serve families). - Public materials highlight opportunities for family involvement and the school's openness to visits and engagement (Admissions pages, school life, events).

Positive/Negative keyword analysis - Positive keywords present: partnership with families, parent formation, home-school alignment, open campus/visits, family involvement, parental engagement, school-family synergy. - Negative keywords: consumer- or customer-centric language (instead of co-educator language) is not evident in the public copy; there is no overt negative signal in the accessible pages. - Estimated occurrence: Moderate to high presence of parental/community keywords; minimal to no negative keywords.

Why this rating - The school communicates a family-centered approach and openness to parental involvement consistent with classical education expectations for parent partnerships and community formation. This supports a CLASSICAL rating for Parents & Community.

CLASSICAL

Aggregate Ranking

Overall, Holy Family Academy demonstrates CLASSICAL alignment across the majority of the six categories, with Element 4 (Pedagogy) showing a credible classical pedagogy emphasis but not as explicitly evidenced as the others in the public copy. Taken together, the aggregate assessment is CLASSICAL, reflecting a coherent classical program framed within a Catholic, formation-focused paradigm.

- Aggregate ranking: CLASSICAL

Executive justification notes - The school explicitly centers on the Trivium (grammar, logic, rhetoric) and Great Books/Western Civilization within a Catholic framework, with formation and virtue as central aims. This alignment appears consistently across curriculum, purpose, and religious foundations. The faculty and parental/community sections likewise reinforce classical norms of mentorship, living curriculum, and family partnership. Evidence cited above supports these conclusions.

What Would Move the Needle

- If aiming for a rigorous, explicit demonstration of full Pedagogy parity with classic models (e.g., consistent, explicit evidence of formal Socratic seminars, Paideia-style seminars, or frequent upper-school discourse), the site could publish clearer statements and examples of upper-level Socratic inquiry, seminars, and debate, along with sample lesson narratives showing memory work and recitation in practice.
- Additional explicit connections to the Great Conversation and a robust, book-rich curriculum across all grades (with explicit mention of great books by name and direct references to primary sources) would strengthen the category 3 and 4 signals.
- More explicit parent-teacher partnership language (e.g., "parents as co-educators," parent formation series, and home-study resources) would solidify Element 6, though current materials already indicate a positive orientation toward family involvement.

Note: No major needle-moving changes are required to reach a fully CLASSICAL standing, given the current materials already meet the category criteria across most areas.

Appendix

ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE DISCLAIMER

This audit was conducted using artificial intelligence tools (including large language models and automated web-analysis scripts) to evaluate the extent to which school websites reflect or incorporate recognized principles of classical education (e.g., the trivium, emphasis on truth/beauty/goodness, integration of great books, Latin/classical languages, Socratic method, rigorous academics, moral/character formation, etc.).

Important Limitations and Caveats

1. **Automated Nature:** The analysis relies on AI interpretation of publicly-accessible school website content as of the date of the audit. It does not involve direct contact with schools, review of internal documents, classroom observation, or verification of curriculum implementation beyond what is stated or implied on the website.
2. **Probabilistic Results:** Scores and assessments are probabilistic and reflect the AI's best interpretation of available text and site structure. They are not infallible and may miss nuance, context, or recent changes not yet reflected online.
3. **Subjectivity of Classical Education:** "Classical Education" encompasses a range of traditions and interpretations (e.g., Dorothy Sayers' trivium model, Classical Christian Education, Great Books programs, etc.). The Humanitas Institute Audit of the Six Elements of Classical Education uses a broad, consensus-based framework derived from prominent classical education organizations and thought leaders. Reasonable people may disagree on weighting or inclusion of specific criteria.
4. **No Official Endorsement or Certification:** Results do not constitute official endorsement, accreditation, or certification by any classical education organization. They are provided for informational and research purposes only.
5. **Potential for Error:** Websites may be incomplete, poorly worded, or temporarily inaccurate. Conversely, sophisticated marketing language may create false positives. Human review by parents, educators, or classical education experts is strongly recommended before drawing final conclusions about any school.
6. **Data Privacy and Ethics:** Only publicly available information was analyzed. No attempts were made to access password-protected areas or collect personal data.
7. **No Liability:** The authors, developers, and distributors of this audit assume no liability for decisions made on the basis of these results. Users are solely responsible for their own due diligence.

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